

CLOTHES AND FASHION



PEOPLE HAVE ALWAYS WORN CLOTHES, either as protection from the weather or for modesty. Yet through history, people have also chosen clothes to impress or attract others, or to reflect their job, social status, or religious beliefs. Clothes send out signals about the wearer's lifestyle and the type of society they live in: for instance, during the 20th century, the emancipation of women was reflected in the kind of clothes they wore, such as practical trousers.

Clothing design

Designers choose the fabric, colour, and shape of a garment. Their decisions are influenced by the function of the item, and who will eventually wear it. A work shirt, for example, must be made from durable fabric; a high-fashion shirt can be made from less practical silk or linen.

Sample of fabric



Sketched design

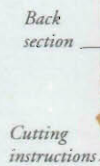
Design

Some designers sketch their ideas for a new style onto paper. Others work directly with the fabric, draping it over a dressmaker's dummy, and pinning it until the right shape emerges.

Pattern

Once the design has been decided, it is translated into pattern pieces, made from paper or card. These are used as a guide for cutting out the fabric. The pattern pieces are made in different sizes, and sent to the cutting room.

Sample pattern



Back section

Sleeve

Cutting instructions

Daily wear

The popular informal outfit of shirt, jeans, and trainers can be seen in many parts of the world, worn by both sexes of all ages. This casual outfit is an example of the changing attitudes to clothes seen in the 20th century. For the first time, everyday clothing crossed barriers of age, gender, and social class.

Clothing manufacture

The clothes manufacturing industry is massive, and employs millions of people worldwide. Some designs are exclusive, produced by the great fashion houses. Most clothes however are manufactured in standard sizes and, from cutting to pressing, are mass-produced in factories.



Sewing

The cut pieces are carried to the person whose job it is to match them up for the sewing machinist. Each machinist concentrates on a particular part of the garment, such as the sleeves.



Cutting

Up to 150 layers of fabric are spread out on long tables. The pattern pieces are then laid on top and the material is cut, using either a mechanical knife or a laser.



Pressing

Once the clothes are sewn together, they are laid on large, flat tables to be pressed. Then a final inspection is held to check the quality of the finished garment, before it is sold to a wholesaler.

Sports cap is now casual everyday wear



Hats

In the early and mid-20th century, adults usually wore hats in public. The way people dress has become less formal since then, and the hat's importance as a smart accessory has declined.



Belt

Shirts

In medieval Europe, shirts were worn beneath a tunic. Over the years, more and more of the shirt was allowed to show, and now it is regarded as an outer garment. Everyday shirts need to be hard-wearing and easy to put on.

Jeans

Bavarian-born retailer Levi Strauss (1829–1902) sold the first blue jeans – Levis – to miners in the 1850s. They have been popular ever since, because they are hard-wearing, and easily adapted to changes in fashion.

Trainers

Trainers were originally made for tennis or basketball players – the rubber soles stopped them from slipping. They have since become fashionable "street" wear.

Leather or fabric upper



Rubber sole

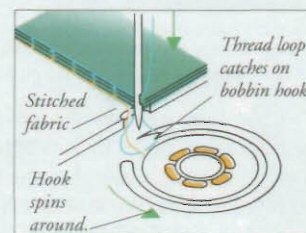


Cotton

Computerized control panel

Sewing machine

To make a stitch, a sewing machine must loop one thread around another. The latest models are computerized: touching a panel changes the type of stitch. Domestic machines perform about 1,000 stitches a minute; industrial machines are ten times faster.



1 As the needle pierces the fabric, it makes a loop of thread, which is picked up by a bobbin hook beneath the needle plate.



2 The loop is pulled around thread drawn from within the bobbin, joining the top thread as a stitch. Both threads are then released.